

INTO THIN AIR

A FIELD REPORT ON THE 1996 EVEREST DISASTER

A breakdown of the systemic failures, commercial pressures, and human errors leading to the deadliest season in the mountain's history.



BASED ON THE ACCOUNT BY JON KRAKAUER



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EXPEDITION FILE - EVE'96

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MISSION STATUS

DATE: May 10, 1996

TIME: 1:17 PM

STATUS: 57 hours without sleep.

INTAKE: 1 bowl ramen + handful peanut
M&Ms in 3 days.

PHYSIOLOGY: Separated ribs. Cognitive
capacity of a child.

"There was no euphoria. Standing with one foot
in China and one in Nepal, the primary emotion
was not triumph, but a detached lethargy."

THE OBSESSION: A TIMELINE

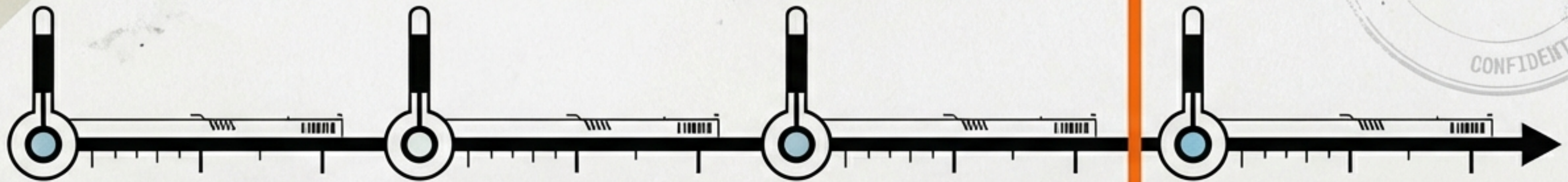


ALTIMETER

SEA LEVEL
(CONTEXT)

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1852: DISCOVERY

Peak XV identified as highest point on Earth.

1924: THE MYSTERY

Mallory & Irvine disappear. "Because it is there."

1953: THE CONQUEST

Hillary & Tenzing summit. Coronation Everest.

1985: THE COMMODITY

Dick Bass summits. The birth of the "Seven Summits" commercial craze.

"The mountain still holds the master card ... it will grant success only in its own good time." - Eric Shipton

THE PIVOT POINT

THE ECONOMICS OF 1996

REVENUE & FEES

 **NEPAL GOV PERMIT:** \$10,000 - \$70,000 per team.

 **CLIENT FEE (ADVENTURE CONSULTANTS):** \$65,000 per head.

 **TOTAL EXPEDITIONS:** 30 teams on mountain.

 **COMMERCIAL TEAMS:** 10.

TECHNICAL ANNOTATION: (YESYNIEBSCAL ANNOTATION

x
x

- -

- -

- -

+

FINANCIAL TOTAL

TOTAL

THE ASSIGNMENT (OUTSIDE MAGAZINE)

-  **ORIGINAL PLAN:** Base Camp reporting only.
-  **NEW PLAN:** Summit team participation.
-  **THE BARTER DEAL:** Rob Hall offers steep discount in exchange for advertising space. Hall needs exposure to compete with US rivals.

**COMMERCIAL
PRESSURE**

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EXPEDITION FILE - EVE'96 - SAFETY ORANGE



TEAM ADVENTURE CONSULTANTS (NEW ZEALAND)

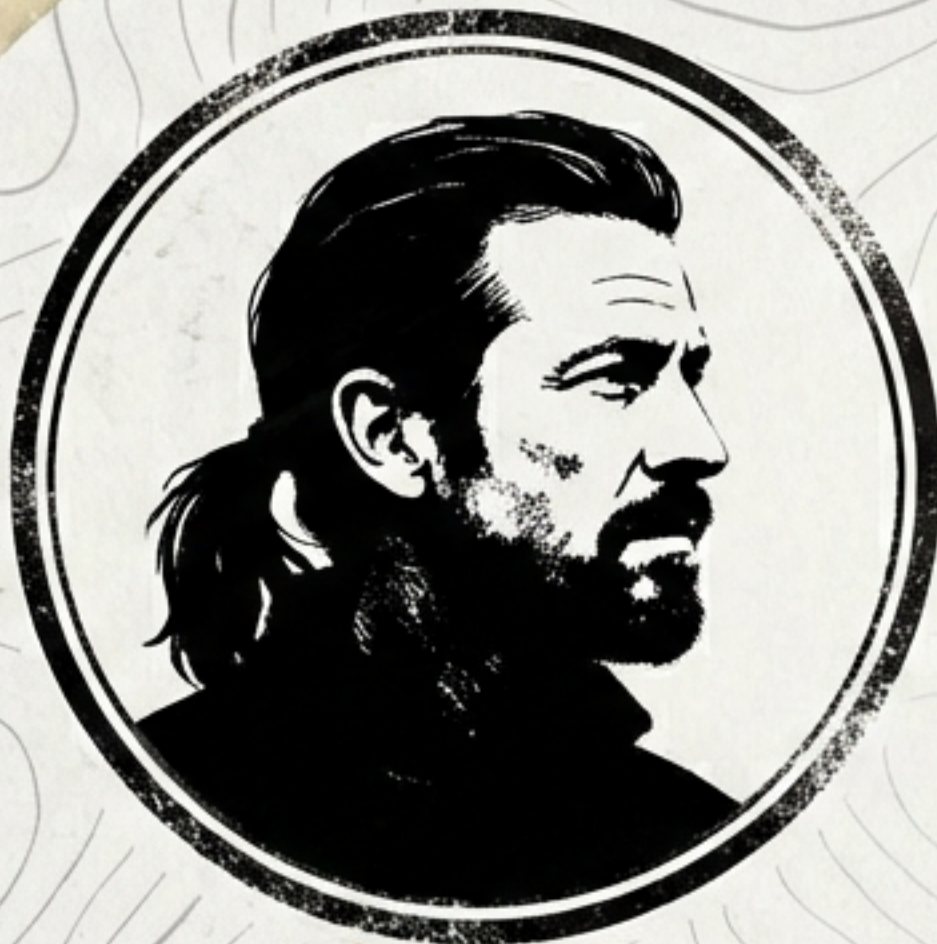
LEADER: ROB HALL (35)

ATTRIBUTES

- Methodical, scientific, infrastructure-heavy.
- Track Record (1990-1995): Guided 39 clients to the summit.
- Motivation: Securing future US market share via publicity.

LEADER'S PHILOSOPHY (TYPEWRITER):

"We will not drag you up a mountain... but we guarantee to maximise the safety and success of your adventure."



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EXPEDITION FILE - EVE'06 - SAFETY ORANGE

TEAM MOUNTAIN MADNESS (USA)

LEADER: SCOTT FISCHER (40)

ATTRIBUTES

- Charismatic, 'Cowboy' attitude.
- Organizational Style: Loose, 'Coffee & Cannabis'.
- History: Survived 70ft fall into crevasse; impaled leg.
- Motivation: New business needing a successful season to become profitable.

LEADER'S PHILOSOPHY (TYPEWRITER):

"Experience is overrated. It's not the altitude that's important, it's your attitude."

THE CLIENT MANIFEST

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EXPEDITION FILE - EVE'06 - SAFETY ORANGE

DOUG HANSEN (46)

The Everyman / Postal Worker.
Second attempt (failed in '95).
Worked night shifts to pay.

BECK WEATHERS (49)

Pathologist.
Ultra-conservative, seeking high
adventure ('Aging Walter Mitty').

YASUKO NAMBA (47)

Personnel Director.
91 lbs. Seeking to be oldest
woman to summit. Completing
Completing Seven Summits.

SANDY HILL PITTMAN

Socialite / Media Correspondent.
Brought espresso maker and
rugs. Seeking media glory.

A ragtag collection of decent softball players bribing their way
into the World Series.

FILE # 1996-AC-RH

EXPEDITION FILE - EVE'06 - SAFETY ORANGE

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EXPEDITION FILE - EVE'96 - SAFETY ORANGE

THE BACKBONE: SHERPA SUPPORT

KEY FIGURE: Ang Dorje (Climbing Sirdar).

ROLE: Young, strong, loyal to Hall.

THE ECONOMICS OF RISK

WAGE: \$1,400 - \$2,500 per season.

CLIENT FEE COMPARISON: \$65,000.

FATALITY STATS: Sherpas account for 1/3 of all historic Everest deaths.

"The pull of Everest was stronger for me than any force on earth." – Tenzing Norgay

FILE # 1996-AC-Rii

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EXPEDITION FILE - EVE'96 - SAFETY ORANGE

OPERATIONAL HAZARDS: THE OTHER TEAMS



THE SOUTH AFRICANS

Leader: Ian Woodall.

Issues: Fraud, lies about military service, refusal to coordinate.

Status: "Deranged" atmosphere.



THE TAIWANESE

Leader: "Makalu" Gau.

Issues: Reputation for incompetence. Previously rescued on McKinley.

Status: Unpredictable.

"With so many incompetent people on the mountain... it's pretty unlikely that we'll get through this season without something bad happening." (Rob Hall)

FILE # 1996-AC-Riii

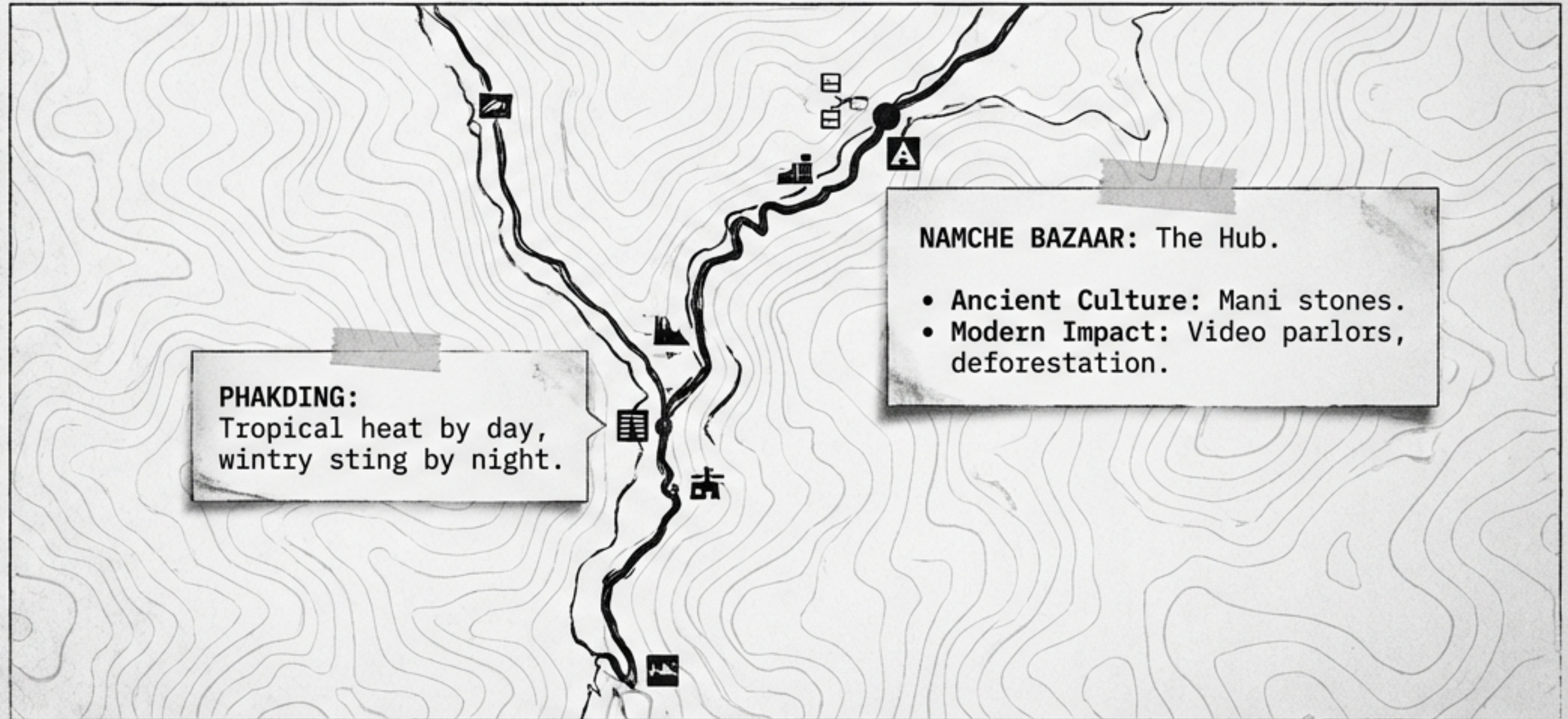
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APPROACH: THE TREK



9,200 FT
(LUKLA)  11,300 FT
(NAMCHE)



SIDEBAR NOTE

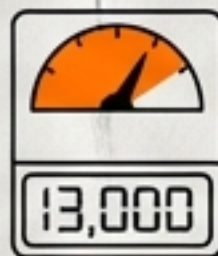
FRICITION:

Conflict arises between Beck Weathers (conservative politics) and Krakauer.

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EXPEDITION FILE - EVE'96 - SAFETY ORANGE

ACCLIMATIZATION: SPIRIT VS SCIENCE



14,000 FT



13,000 FT

TENGBOCHE MONASTERY



- **Ritual:** The Blessing.
- **Artifact:** The Kata scarf.
- **Belief:** Protection from harm.

PHERICHE CLINIC (HRA)



RED FLAG: DEATH ZONE

- **Reality:** The Death Zone.
- **Diagnosis:** **HAAE** (High Altitude Pulmonary Edema) / **HACE** (Cerebral Edema).
- **Physiology:** The body begins to **consume itself**.

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LOBUJE: THE GRIM REALITY

CONDITIONS

- **Environment:** Overflowing excrement, dense acrid smoke (yak dung fires).
- **Health Status:** Krakauer develops 'Khumbu Cough'. Andy Harris violently ill (GI).
- **INCIDENT REPORT:** Tenzing (Sherpa) falls into crevasse. First serious accident.



16,200 FT

GLACIAL BLUE



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EXPEDITION FILE - EVE'96 - SAFETY ORANGE

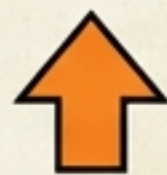
BASE CAMP: CITY ON ICE



SIZE: 300+ tents,
14 expeditions.

ADVENTURE CONSULTANTS HQ
Solar power, library,
fax machines, fresh
bread.

MOUNTAIN MADNESS HQ
"Starbucks Coffee" banner.



17,600 FT

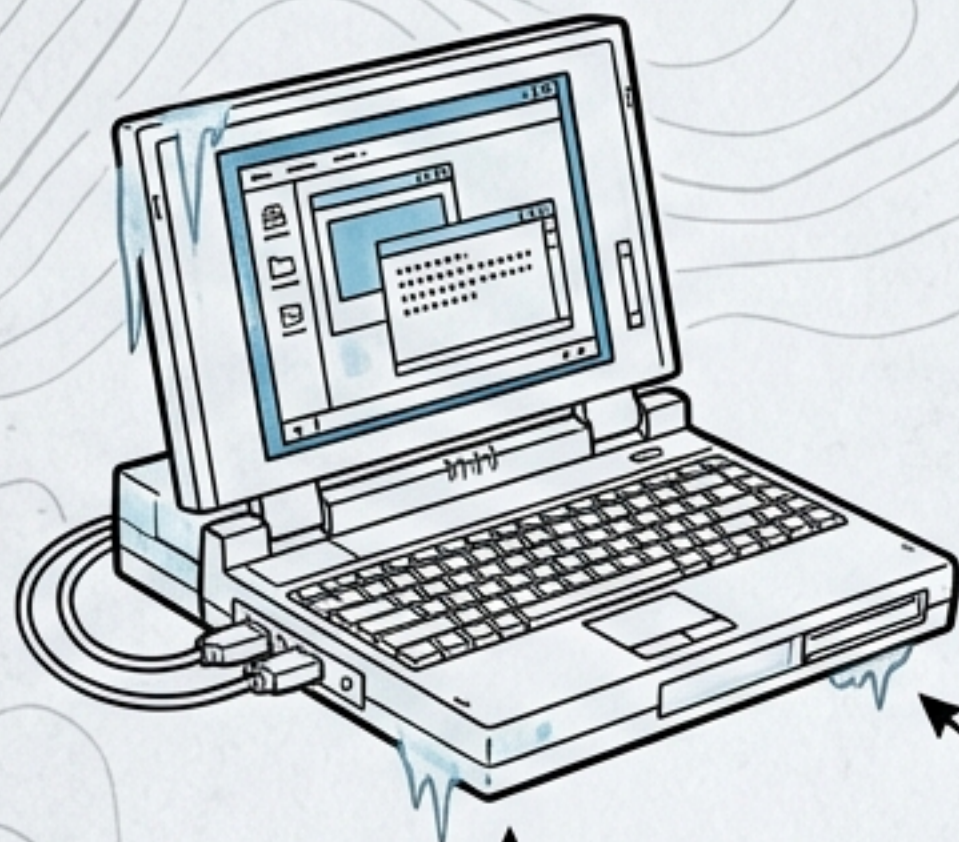
Glacial Prime

Contrast: "Serenaded by a madrigal of creaks" vs. creature comforts.

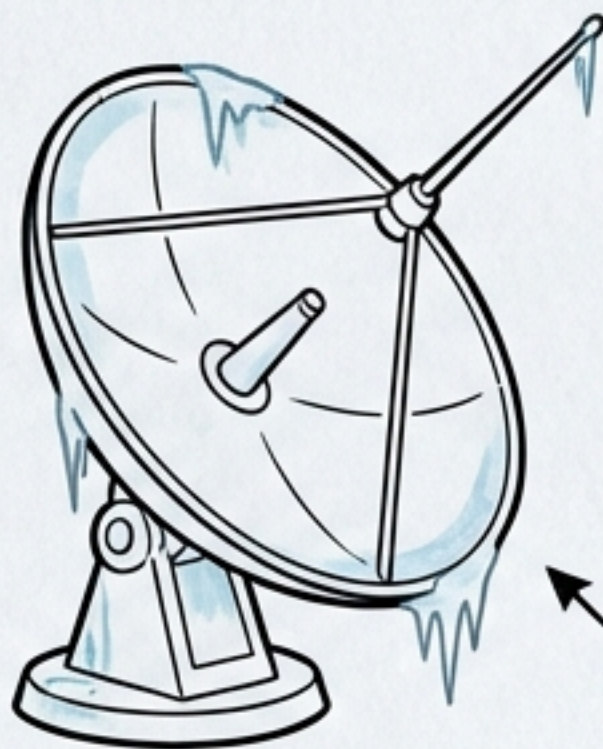
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THE INFORMATION WARP



NBC INTERACTIVE MEDIA:
Sandy Hill Pittman
uploading daily.



THE FISHBOWL:
Daily dispatches
to websites.



RESULT: Spouses at
home knew more about
team movements than
climbers at Base Camp.

RED FLAG

OBSTACLE 1: THE KHUMBU ICEFALL

Velocity:

Ice moves 3-4 feet per day.

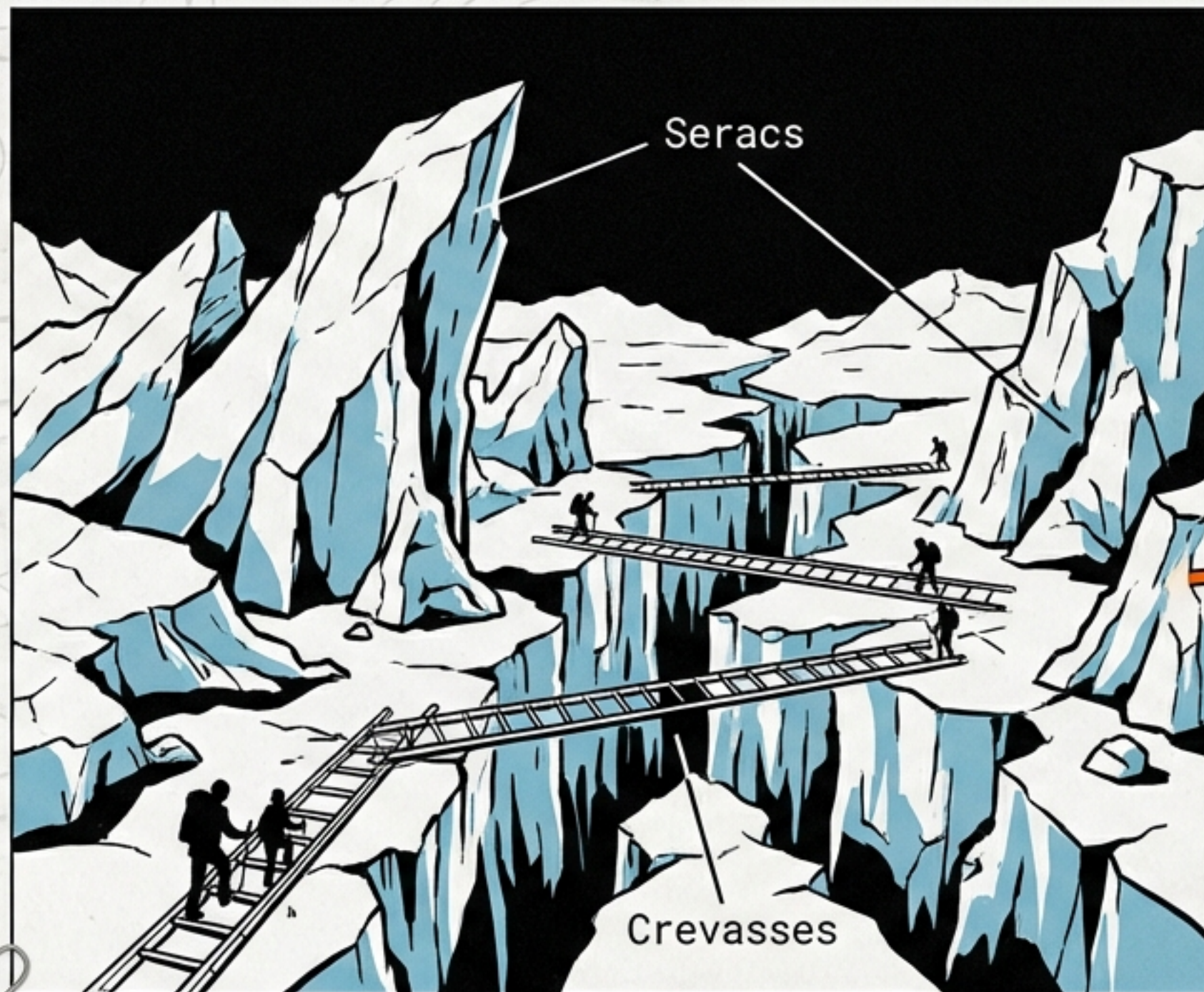
Hazard:

The Mousetrap (leaning serac).

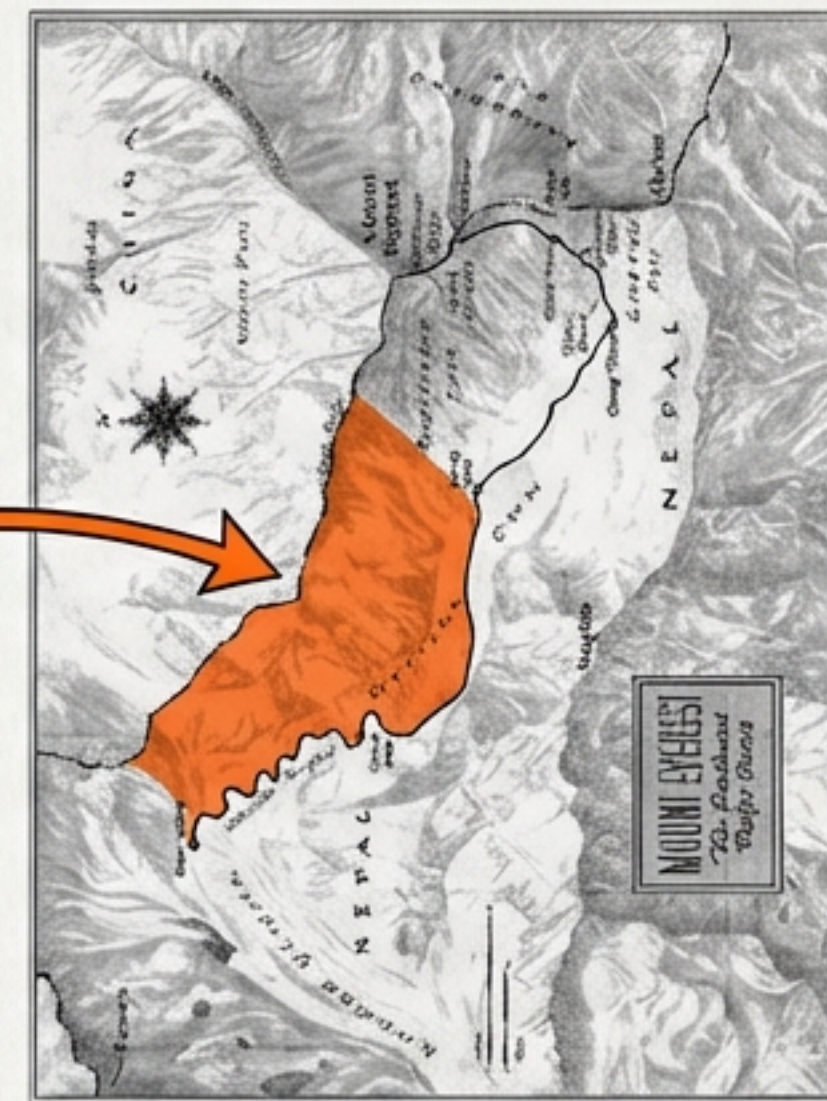
Technique:

Aluminum ladders lashed together.

Risk Assessment:
Russian Roulette.



18,000 - 19,000 FT



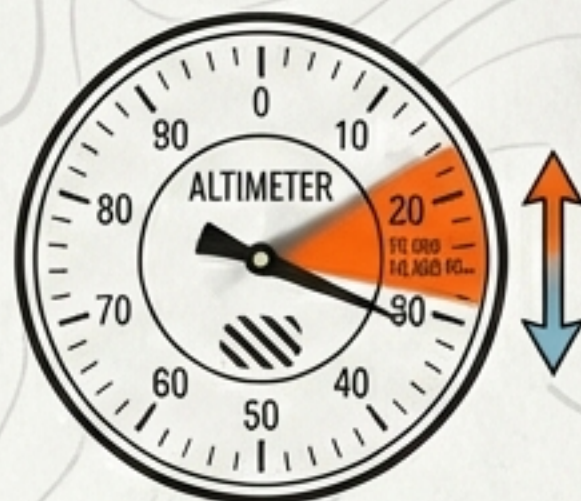
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THE GRIND: ACCLIMATIZATION

THE WESTERN CWM (Valley of Silence)

- **Conditions:** Extreme heat (Solar Oven).
- **Camp Two:** Advanced Base Camp (120 tents).
- **Physical Decay:** Muscle atrophy, cuts won't heal, insomnia.
- **Strategy:** Climb high, sleep low.

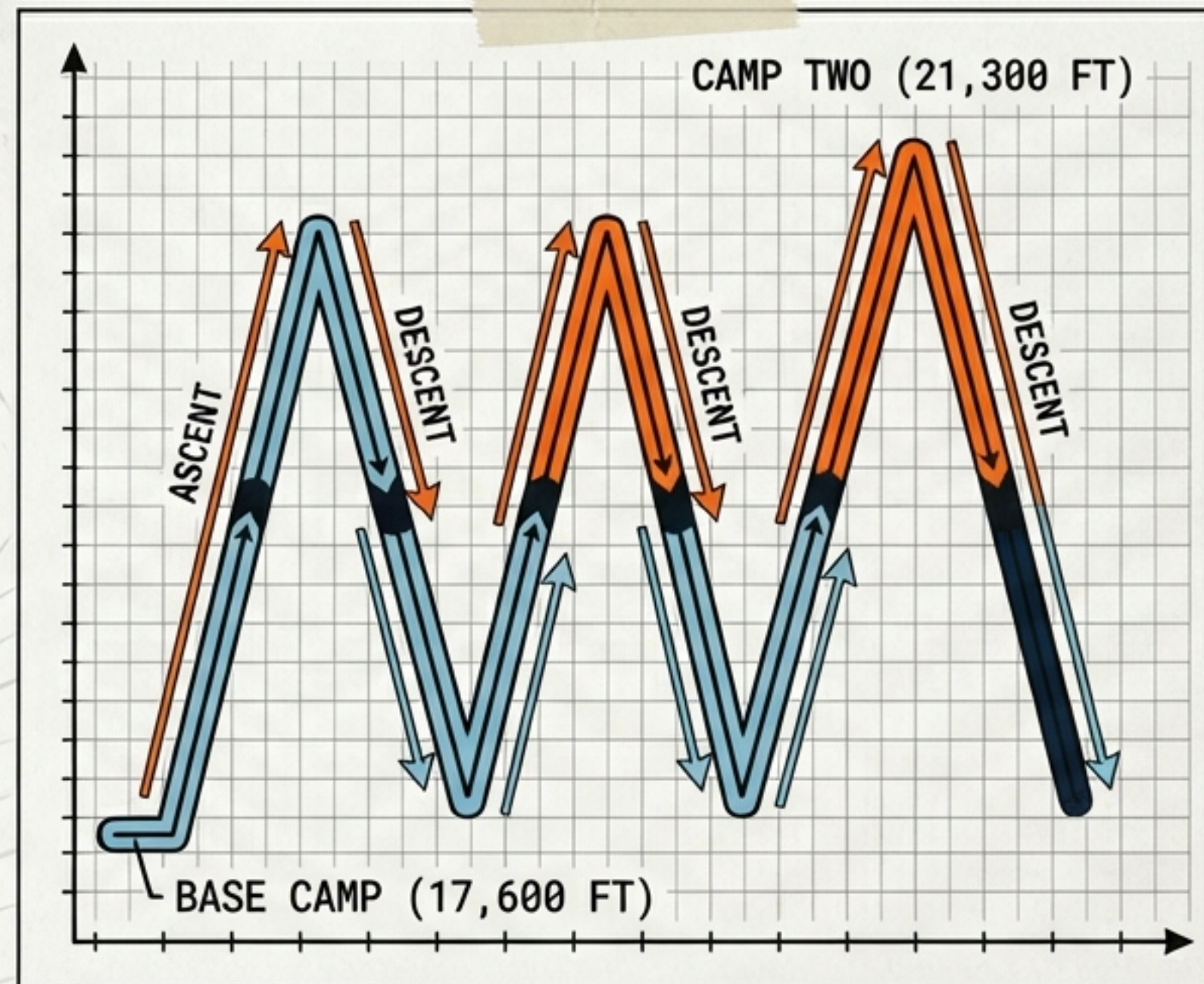
SAFETY ORANGE
**RED
FLAG**



17,600 FT ↔ 21,300 FT



WESTERN CWM HEAT TRAP.



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WARNING SIGNS: INEXPERIENCE

SAFETY ORANGE

RED
FLAG

“We’ve built a
yellow brick road
to the summit.”

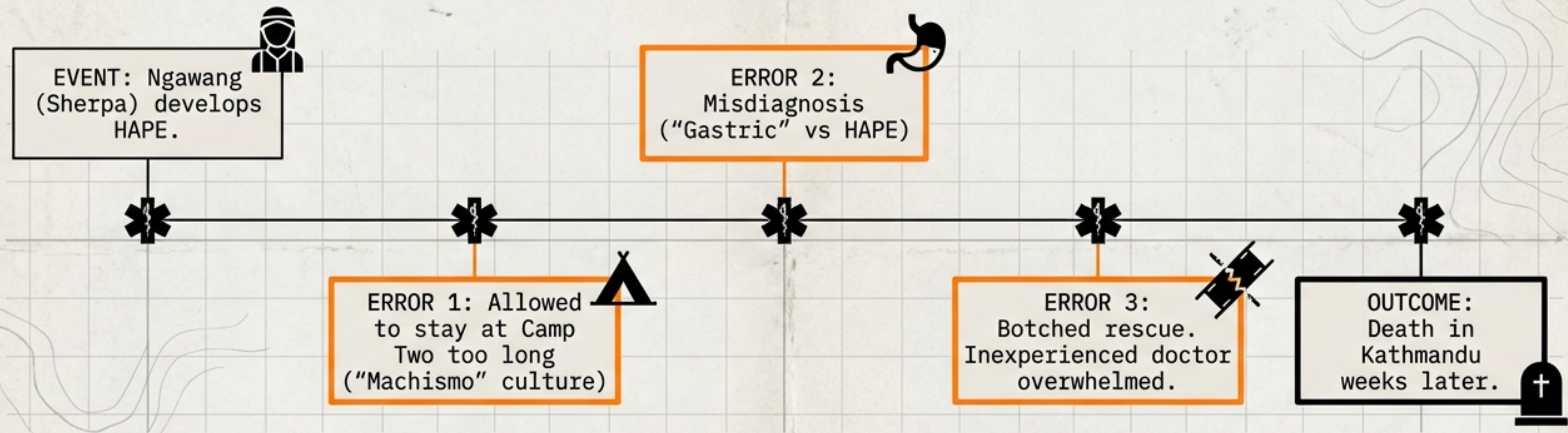
- **EQUIPMENT FAILURE**: Yasuko Namba attempts to use crampons incorrectly; near fall.
- **EXHAUSTION**: Clients struggling to reach Camp One.
- **DEPENDENCY**: Fischer’s team dragging clients.

“Some people don’t understand
that an Everest expedition can’t
be run like a Swiss train.”
— Scott Fischer.

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CASUALTY REPORT: NGAWANG TOPCHE



A breakdown in leadership and communication before the summit push begins.

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16:9

“DISTRACTIONS AND VANITY”



THE SOLOIST (Petter Neby)

The mountain is treated as a stage.



THE SOCIALITE (Sandy Pittman
receiving Vogue/Vanity Fair via DHL)

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THE TRAP IS SET

**“It’s inevitable that a major
disaster will happen...
but it won’t be me.”**

— ROB HALL.

ACCLIMATIZATION COMPLETE. TARGET DATE: May 10th.

FILE # 1996-AC-Riii

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REFLECTION

The staggering unreliability
of the human mind at high
altitude.

"I was a party to the death of
good people, which is so
something that is apt to remain
on my conscience for a very
long time." – Krakauer

*Andy Harris, Doug Hansen, Rob Hall,
Yasuko Namba, Scott Fischer, Ngawang
Topche Sherpa, Chen Yu-Nan, Bruce Herrod,
Lopsang Jangbu Sherpa, and Anatoli Boukreev*

